



Switching hats: After troubling batters for years with seam and swing, Irfan Pathan now provides his insights into the gentleman's game from behind the microphone.

G. P. SAMPATH KUMAR

commentary in six languages from 2018. By 2022, this number increased to eight, including English, Hindi, Bengali, Kannada, Malayalam, Tamil, Telugu, and Marathi. **In the 2023 season, Jio Cinemas and Star Sports introduced commentary services in Gujarati, Odiya, Bhojpuri, and Punjabi, catering to a diverse domestic audience. This year, there will be a Haryanvi feed as well.**

Former India fast bowler Irfan Pathan, who is now into mentoring and commentary, believes that the IPL is the 'biggest cricketing job factory ever'. "If you look at it, so many retired cricketers have found newer avenues. Even if you have not played in the IPL, after retirement, you have options of making vlogs, getting commentary stints and those two months are busy for all," Pathan says.

Apart from the global feed that's assigned by the BCCI, which has a separate panel of commentators, the broadcasters also engage more than 50 to 100 former players for their

regional commentary and chat shows. The pay package varies between Rs 25 to Rs 2 crore depending on the grade and the category. "No other cricketing league has been able to pull off something like the IPL, and as the league grows and the revenue increases, it has a direct impact on allied sectors as well, and that provides several openings for former players," Pathan points out.

"Not just cricket, even other sectors - tourism, hotels, hospitality - also boom, so during those two months, there's an economic progress as well. That automatically trickles down to other sector and the people associated with it."

Ever since the tournament began, overseas coaches and commentators have also bagged lucrative deals and the trend continues.

"The competition has also gone up," says Deep Dasgupta. The former India wicketkeeper, who retired from all forms of the game more than a decade ago, has been a noted commentator and broadcaster. He currently heads Chennai Super Kings' academy in England. "If you look from the perspective of the sports industry, the more it grows, the whole ecosystem grows. So, obviously, the competition is intense, but then, it's also in a much better shape that

where things were maybe 20 years ago," Dasgupta says.

There are also flip sides to it. "The market has become competitive with more and more people wanting to get into the groove. Earlier, maybe from a pool of five, you could choose three commentators, but now, you need to pick ten or twelve from a pool of 100, so it is challenging," Dasgupta says.

Given the global nature of the IPL, broadcasters make a conscious effort to maintain a balanced representation of both Indian and overseas experts in their lineup. This emphasis on diversity has led to increased opportunities for players, particularly in regional languages.

"Earlier, things were not that streamlined, but now, with broadcast in so many languages - Marathi, Telugu, Tamil, Bengali - the market has opened up, creating job opportunities and for a league to grow, these are great signs," says Pandit, who's had brief stints in commentary in the past.

Over the last five years, quite a few noted Ranji Trophy cricketers — Dhawal Kulkarni, Amol Muzumdar, Manoj Tiwary, Shreevats Goswami, Hanuma Vihari, Abhinav Mukund — have joined the regional commentary set up. To add further gloss to the coverage last season, Sports18 added former India women's team captain Jhulan Goswami to its roster for Bengali commentary.

Several retired players have found opportunities to work overseas, thanks to Indian franchises investing in various international leagues. "But the number is less," points out a franchise official. The BCCI does not allow its players to feature in overseas leagues, and there are some informal obligations for the staff involved with domestic cricket. "India's domestic tournaments are on around that time, so obviously, the franchises prefer local coaches for the overseas leagues," a franchise insider says.

Not long ago, a retirement from the game often meant the end of road for a cricketer, but IPL has been a glimmer of hope; a platform to stay associated with the game and also earn a living.